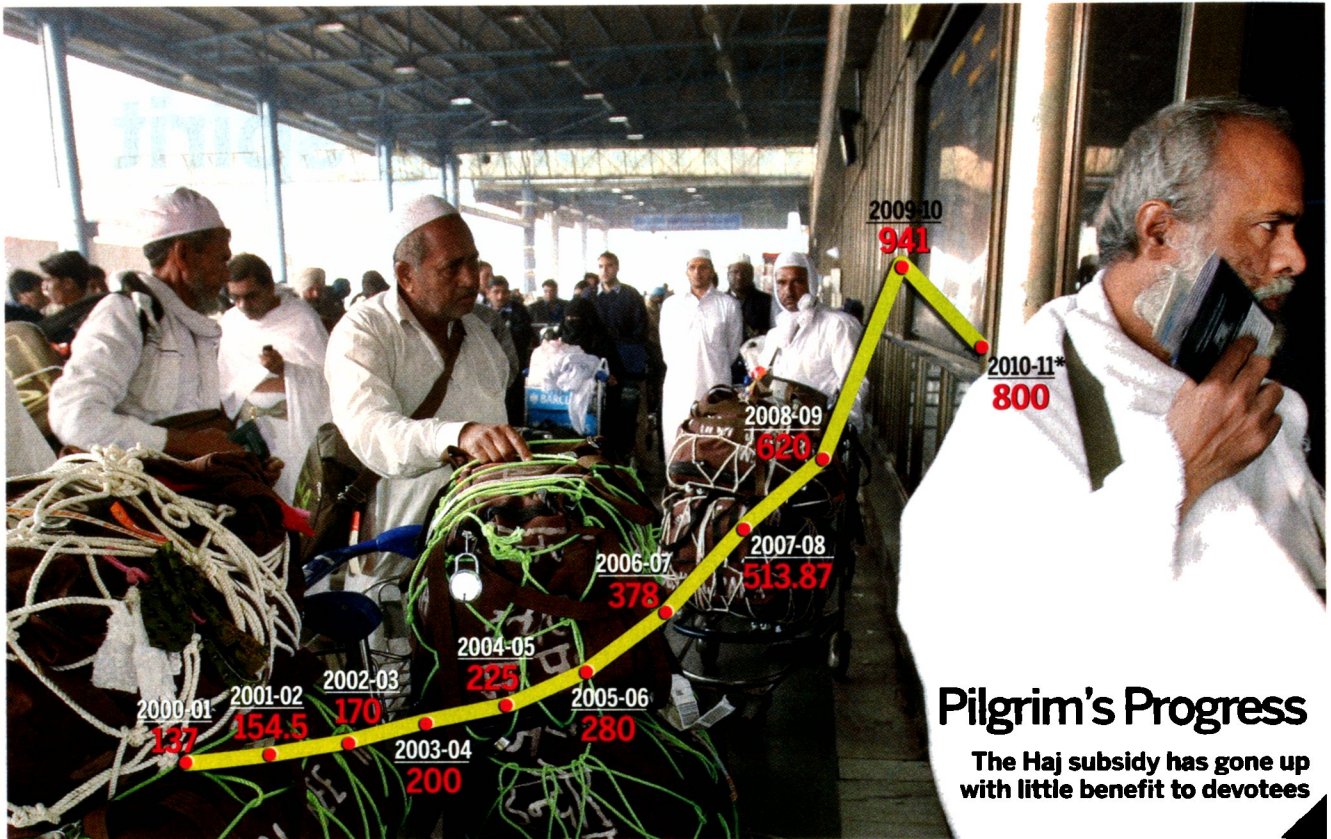




Pilgrim's Progress

The Haj subsidy has gone up with little benefit to devotees

All figures in Rs crore *Budget estimate

DELHI | The Haj Hagggle

The Haj subsidy to Air India, touching Rs 941 crore for 2009-10, has always stood for a darker shade of minority politics. Now when the UPA Government has moved a plan to phase out the subsidy for pilgrims, many expected a backlash from the Muslim leadership. But the community is applauding the plan to stop the Haj airfare subsidy, which was said to have made Muslims pawns in the appeasement game. The subsidy was introduced in the early '70s after the oil crisis which caused losses to Moghul Line—a Shipping Corporation of India subsidiary—which operated a four-ship Haj service. The Government's current phase-out, though, is expected to run into trouble, particularly because there is no convincing alternate plan. Muslim organisations, including the Muslim Personal Law Board, are asking the Government to put an end to Air India's Haj baggage, which amounts to about Rs 57,000 per pilgrim. The pilgrims, about 1.65 lakh a year, contribute Rs 12,000 each besides spending over Rs 1 lakh each on their accommodation and transportation in Saudi Arabia. Competitive bidding between airlines can bring the travel costs of the pilgrims down to almost what they actually pay. Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Rahman Khan and some Muslim MPs have called for a fund to pool and invest the savings of the pilgrims. Good economics, perhaps. But it will take stronger political will to deal with votebank politics.

by Shafi Rahman

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crore rupees was the amount of the subsidy given to Air India for ferrying 1.65 lakh Haj pilgrims during the year 2009-2010.

HAJ PILGRIMS
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